



Individualized Business Plan

An Individualized Business Plan (IBP) outlines vocational rehabilitation (VR) services designed for a business customer. This strategy was created by the National Employment Team (NET) and has been implemented in several states. Just as VR counselors develop an Individual Plan for Employment (IPE) for clients, Business Engagement Specialists (BES) are encouraged to develop an individual plan for employers they work with.

It can take time to learn about the business and its needs. Typically, you can create an IBP for a business after you have gotten past your initial interactions. The IBP is intended to capture both short-term and long-term needs and services. The following are some considerations as you decide whether to propose an IBP to a business:

- » Does the business have multiple needs for which VR can provide services?
- » Is it a small business with the owner performing all management tasks that can benefit from a long-term approach, with services and resources being provided incrementally?
- » Is it a mid-size or large business with various departments (e.g., Human Resources, Information Technology) having specific needs?
- » Does the business have the infrastructure to hold up their end of the deal?
- » Are there areas VR cannot address directly, but that could be addressed by another workforce partner?
- » Once you have established that an IBP will support your relationship with the business, you will want to complete the following six steps

Steps to Developing an IBP





Needs Assessment

Gather as much information as possible about the business



The first step is to conduct a needs assessment. Start by determining how VR can support the business in addressing their immediate needs and long-term goals. You may be able to identify opportunities the business is not aware of. Gather as much information as possible (e.g., history, core values, size, environment) from your interactions with the business, through online research and through your network. Take note of educational requirements for their workforce, job site analysis, job match (knowledge, skills, and abilities), assistive technology, rehabilitation engineering, financial incentives, retention services, customer outreach, and marketing. This information will be valuable in determining what services to offer and in making the best match possible with potential job seekers.

STEP 2

Needs Analysis

Compile a list of the needs or interests



You can decide if a business will benefit from an IBP by using the information from the needs assessment and the questions in the table below. If you determine that it will, introduce the concept to the business and see if they are interested. Compile a list of the needs, goals or interests you have been discussing. These will be the focus areas of the IBP. For each focus area, assess whether VR is able to support their needs and if not, determine if there is a partner to whom you can refer them.

Question	Yes/No	Propose IBP	Response
Is there an urgent hiring need?	Yes	Not now, maybe later. Support the immediate hiring need and develop the relationship.	Start here. Refer applicants and connect to partners.
Are there needs other than hiring?	Yes	Yes	Explore the needs and match to VR services.
Are they talking about diversifying their staff?	Yes	Yes	Offer disability awareness training and accessibility review.
Are they asking about the needs of an aging workforce or workers with acquired disabilities?	Yes	Yes	Offer disability awareness training, accessibility review, and employee consultation.
Is this a family business or cultural organization with set ideas about how plans are made and how partnerships are developed?	Yes	Possibly. Explore their interest and goals.	Explore their approach. Listen to and respect what they want.
Are there emerging or growth areas for the business that impact their future staffing needs?	Yes	Yes	Ask them to project ahead and offer services to address long-term needs.



Create Business Proposal



Identify a range of opportunities for collaboration

Now that you and the business have agreed to develop an IBP, create a proposal or draft plan. Identify a range of opportunities for collaboration, possibly including staff training, consultation on accommodations, candidate referrals, and work-based learning activities. Review this draft plan with the business to gauge their interests in the services you can provide. Remember, you could deliver some of the services in coordination with a partner organization. The IBP consists of the following three core components:

- 1) Overview of the business: include information gathered in the needs assessment
- 2) Identification of business needs: the focus areas determined in the needs analysis
- 3) Proposed services: include all the necessary elements, services, and timelines



Finalize Written IBP

Include the services based they've said they are ready for



Based on your conversation with the business about the draft plan, create a formal written plan. Include a list of all the needs and goals. Then, prioritize the services based on what the business is ready for.

Here is a list of potential services to include:

- » Work-based learning activities, such as informational interviews, company tours, job shadows, short-term work experiences, on-the-job-training, internships, and apprenticeships
- » Work site assessments for accessibility, accommodations, assistive technology, and universal design to benefit employees as well as customers and other business partners
- » Assistance diversifying their applicant pool and workforce
- » Assistance with job descriptions, task analysis, and job re-design
- » Assistance with backfilling vacancies created by employee advancement
- » Retention planning and supports
- » Staff training on disability awareness, ADA, affirmative action, and reasonable accommodations
- » Marketing and outreach to customers with disabilities to diversify the applicant pool and workforce
- » Financial supports like Work Opportunity Tax Credit



Implement the Plan

Deliver consistent, quality services



Once you've discussed your plan and finalized it, it's time to implement the plan. Deliver consistent, quality services based on the employer's needs and interests. Know your own limitations and bring in community partners as appropriate. Be available and responsive to the business and their changing needs.



STEP 6

Follow-up

After the business has received their first service, follow up



After the business has received their first service, follow up with them. Find out how it went and identify any consultation or supports they may need. Give them the opportunity to provide you feedback on how things went and their satisfaction with your services. Let them know that you are there for them and ready to help. Review the proposal and modify it as needed. The IBP is meant to be a living, not static, document that reflects the current realities of the business and your working relationship with them.

In the effort to develop a long-term relationship with the business that will lead to inclusion of people with disabilities in their workforce, your goal is to meet their needs and contribute to their bottom line. Don't forget, it is about establishing trust!



Vocational Rehabilitation Agency Name
Individualized Business Plan
Business Name
Date

Overview of Business

Brief description of the business: What they do, business size, locations, certifications/skills/training needs for staff.

Identification of Business Needs

We identified the following needs from our discussions:

Comprehensive list of needs and wants, (e.g., expansion in next year, disability specific asks). Include immediate as well as long-term goals/needs.

Proposed Services from Your Vocational Rehabilitation Agency

Based on our conversation, we identified the following services and supports to address your needs:

Focus Area #1:

One of the business' identified goals/needs

Proposed service 1: service VR can offer to support the business in attaining their goal or addressing their need

- **Action steps and activities:** list all steps/activities for service #1
- **Primary Lead (for each party):** include who from the VR agency, business, and relevant partners will take the lead in executing or coordinating the activities (e.g., BES, Business Hiring Manager)
- **Timeframe for the service:** include start/end dates (please note, there may be multiple dates depending on the necessary action steps)

Proposed service 2: second service VR can offer to support the business in attaining their goal or addressing their need

- **Action steps and activities:** list all steps/activities for service #2
- **Primary Lead (for each party):** include who from the VR agency, business, and relevant partners will take the lead in executing or coordinating the activities (e.g., BES, Business Hiring Manager)
- **Timeframe for the service:** include start/end dates (there may be multiple dates depending on the necessary action steps)

*Add additional services as needed

Focus Area #2:

Another of the business' identified goals/needs

Proposed service 1: service VR can offer to support the business in attaining their goal or addressing their need

- **Action steps and activities:** list all steps/activities for service #1
- **Primary Lead (for each party):** include who from the VR agency, business, and relevant partners will take the lead in executing or coordinating the activities (e.g., BES, Business Hiring Manager)
- **Timeframe for the service:** include start/end date (there may be multiple dates depending on the necessary action steps)

Proposed service 2: second service VR can offer to support the business in attaining their goal or addressing their need

- **Action steps and activities:** list all steps/activities for service #2
- **Primary Lead (for each party):** include who from the VR agency, business, and relevant partners will take the lead in executing or coordinating the activities (e.g., BES, Business Hiring Manager)
- **Timeframe for the service:** include start/end dates (there may be multiple dates depending on the necessary action steps)

*Add additional focus areas and services as needed

Please contact BES name, title with any questions, modifications, and/or recommendations at email or phone #.



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